

1. What Do We Do?

Codex is not merely a text generator attached to a repository. In current OpenAI documentation it is an agentic work environment that can inspect code, run commands, use browsers and computer tools, work with external systems, split work across agents, and verify results. GPT-6 Astra is the current frontier model for the hardest end-to-end work. The practical problem is therefore not just "what prompt should I write?" but "what arrangement of goal, evidence, tools, permissions, and checks makes a result trustworthy?"

Questions for the course:

- What information belongs in the initial request, and what should Astra discover from the repository or connected tools?
- When should the model infer details, and when should it ask a focused question?
- When is Low or Medium reasoning enough? What observation would justify High, XHigh, or Max?
- Which tool should carry the task: shell, browser, Chrome, Computer Use, a plugin, or a subagent?
- What does a durable instruction belong in: the prompt, AGENTS.md, a skill, config, or a plugin?
- What counts as evidence that a change works rather than merely looks plausible?

2. How Do We Do It?

A useful analysis cycle has six stages.

1. Discover. Identify the desired outcome and the real object being changed. Find the repository, current behavior, constraints, and authoritative sources.
2. Explore. Inspect enough of the codebase or environment to learn where the relevant behavior lives. Search before editing. Distinguish direct evidence from guesses.
3. Formalize. Turn the request into explicit success conditions, boundaries, and tests. Decide what the agent is authorized to change and what requires approval.
4. Execute. Choose the narrowest sufficient tools, make the smallest coherent changes, and preserve useful existing structure.
5. Verify. Run the checks that bear on the claim. For UI work, inspect the rendered result; for code, run targeted tests and then broaden only when justified.
6. Hand back. Report the result, remaining uncertainty, and evidence. If the goal is not met, use the evidence to begin the cycle again.

This cycle differs from a long prescriptive prompt. It specifies the epistemic structure of the work: what must be learned, what must be made true, and how anyone will know. Astra's stronger initiative makes that distinction more important, because a capable agent can carry a weakly specified objective a long way in the wrong direction.

References: OpenAI, "GPT-6 Astra: A new generation of intelligence"; OpenAI, Codex; OpenAI, GPT-6 Astra model guidance.

Independent Open Course

<https://github.com/dicnunz/codex-astra-course>

CODEX.00 | Codex with GPT-6 Astra

Handout 1: Basics of Codex with GPT-6 Astra

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